

fix. He wins hand-down over other gurus. "Before me, gurus concentrated on dhyana and asana. I found pranayama to be the simplest for an average person pressed for time," he says. Just the message that couch-potato India wants to hear. His 107 seven-step pranayama doesn't tie you up in knots or leave you zonked for the day.

Wherever he goes, crowds stand in ovation. His Divya Yoga Mandir in Haridwar sees 30,000 footfalls a day (a life membership comes for Rs 1 lakh). His yoga camps attract over 75,000 acolytes. The sale of tickets—between Rs 500 and Rs 2,100—rakes in breathtaking profits. He needs the money, he says, to chase his dream of setting up a Patanjali yoga peeth. Or be the country's "tallest guru," as his followers hold. The Baba is not far from it. At Kumbh, his posters adorn every wall, his tents take up maximum space and his aides flit about in swanky cars. On visits across the country, he stays in the palatial houses of his powerful disciples. And why not? After all, India's Who's Who—from A.P.J. Abdul Kalam, Sharad Pawar, Mulayam Singh Yadav, Lalu Prasad, Ambika Soni, N.D. Tiwari, Vasundhara Raje, to the Hinduja, Bajajs,

Munjals and Goenkas—touch his feet. Nine to 90, politicians to homemakers, from Nainital to New York, devotees come in droves. Ask Seema Gupta, who teaches statistics at Ram Lal Anand College in Delhi: "He addresses everyday problems of life—obesity to hairfall. That's refreshingly different."

Is Ramdev just the item boy of yoga? That's what his peers feel ("He is the least spiritual of yogis"). But they don't understand that in a booming economy godmen can't afford to be cut from the same saffron cloth. They have to reflect the self-confidence of the BlackBerry-wielding professionals thronging their ashrams. Ramdev has the making of a superhero—like an athlete he achieves extraordinary bodily feats; like a celebrity he gives stellar performances before a camera and like a businessman he channels his fortune into programmes for the masses. As India turns 60, the nation's excitement over the swami reflects the secularisation of the godman—for better or for worse.

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NEW-AGE GODMAN:
Ramdev preaching to
his disciples